APPROACHES OF GENDER AND DEVELOPMENT

WOMEN IN DEVELOPMENT (WID)

By the 1970s it had become very clear that women were being left out of development. They were not benefiting significantly from it and in some instances their existing status and position in society was actually being made worse by development.

The WID approach saw **the problem as the exclusion of women** from development programmes and approaches.

As a result, the solution was seen as **integrating women into** such programmes. WID saw women as a group being treated as lacking opportunity to participate in development.

The main task, therefore, **was to improve women's access to resources and their participation in development.**

The WID approach argued for the integration of women into development programmes and planning.

This, it was argued, was the best way to improve women's position in society. There was, for instance, a major emphasis on income-generating projects for women as a means of integration.

Welfare oriented projects dealing with small income-generating projects and activities mostly aimed at women's reproductive role, where nutrition education and family planning were a main feature.

The WID approach, although it had limitations, **increased the visibility of women in development issues.** WID was successful in helping secure a prominent place for women's issues at the United Nations (UN) and other international development agencies.

The UN declared 1975 to 1985 the Decade for Women. One of the major achievements of the decade was the establishment of women in development structures or machineries. In Zambia, for instance, it was during this time that the Women's League of the then ruling political party United National Independence Party (UNIP) was formed as the national machinery to address women's development issues. The Women's League developed a programme of action and a campaign to promote the integration of women in the development process at every level. Over time, it was felt women's integration into development was not taking place due to the lack of an established structure within government to plan, coordinate and monitor the implementation of policy to integrate women. A WID Unit was established in 1986 at the National Commission for Development Planning, the central planning and coordinating body of government. The WID unit was later elevated to a full department. Its focus was the integration of women in development and to ensure that ministries and other implementing bodies worked towards the improvement of the socio-economic conditions of women as the way to ensure their total integration in development.

Why WID Failed

Although the WID approach made demands for women's inclusion in development, **it did not call for changes in the overall social structure or economic system** in which women were to be included.

As such, WID concentrated narrowly on the inequalities between men and women and ignored **the social, cultural, legal and economic** factors that give rise to those inequalities in society.

WID tended to focus on women almost exclusively and assumed that women **were outside the mainstream of development**.

WOMEN AND DEVELOPMENT (WAD)

As a result of criticisms of the WID approach, the Women and Development (WAD) approach arose in the latter part of the 1970s.

Adopting a Marxist feminist approach (**Marxist Feminism** came from the ideas of Karl Marx, which were used to understand the capitalist sources of the oppression of women. focus on the concerns of working women. They try to make people understand that housework and child care is still "real work), the main argument of WAD was that women had always been part of the development processes. WAD asserts/declares that women have always been important economic actors. The work they do both inside and outside the household is critical to the maintenance of society. However, this integration has only served to sustain global inequalities.

Therefore the WID approach that placed emphasis on integrating women into development was not correct.

The main focus of WAD is on the interaction between women and development processes rather than purely on strategies to integrate women into development. WAD saw both women and men as not benefiting from the global economic structures because of disadvantages due to class and the way wealth is distributed.

WAD therefore argued that the integration of women into development was to their disadvantage and only made their inequality worse.

WAD saw **global inequalities** as the main problem facing poor countries and, therefore, the citizens of those countries.

WAD was very persuasive in raising the debate that women have a role not only in reproduction but in production as well. For development to be meaningful for women both these roles have to be acknowledged.

Criticisms of WAD

WAD has been criticised for assuming that the position of women will improve if and when **international structures become more equitable**. In so doing, it sees women's positions as primarily within the structure of international and class inequalities. It therefore underplays/dismisses the role of patriarchy in undermining women's development and does not adequately address the question of social relations between men and women and their impact on development. It has been argued that, although at a theoretical level WAD recognizes and focuses strongly on class, in practical project design and implementation, it tends like WID to group

women together irrespective of other considerations such as class divisions.

GENDER AND DEVELOPMENT (GAD)

In the 1980s further reflections on the development experiences of women gave rise to Gender and Development (GAD).

GAD represented a coming together of many feminist ideas. It sought to bring together both the lessons learned from, and the limitations of, the WID and WAD approaches.

GAD looks at the impact of development on both women and men. It seeks to ensure that both women and men participate in and benefit equally from development and so emphasizes equality of benefit and control.

It recognizes that women may be involved in development, but not necessarily benefit from it. GAD is not concerned with women exclusively but with the way in which gender relations allot/assign specific roles, responsibilities and expectations between men and women, often to the detriment of women.

Development, therefore, is about deep and important changes to relations dealing with gender inequality within society.

This approach also pays particular attention to the oppression of women in the family or the 'private sphere' of women's lives.

As a result, we have seen projects develop addressing issues such as violence against women.

GAD focuses on the social or gender relations (i.e. the division of labour) between men and women in society and seeks to address issues of access and control over resources and power. The GAD approach has also helped us understand that the gender division of labour gives "triple roles" to women in society (Triple roles - Describes three types of work that people do to maintain households and communities. The three categories of work are productive, reproductive and community work). The gender division of labour operates differently from one society and culture to another and it is also dynamic.

The way these roles are analysed and valued affects the way development projects will make certain things a priority or not. Provision for child-care for instance is not likely to be a priority among men planning for development but it is a crucial factor in ensuring women may take advantage of development opportunities for their benefit.

GAD goes further than the other approaches in emphasizing both the reproductive and productive role of women and argues that it is the state's responsibility to support the social reproduction role mostly played by women of caring and nurturing of children.

As such, it treats development as a complex process that is influenced by political, social and economic factors rather than as a state or stage of development. It therefore goes beyond seeing development as mainly economic well-being but also that the social and mental wellbeing of a person is important.

Arising from the GAD analysis is the need for women to organise themselves into a more effective political voice in order to strengthen their legal rights and increase the number of women in decision making.

In Zambia, the response of government in 1996 to these changes in approach was to elevate the WID department to the Gender in Development Division (GIDD) at Cabinet Office, under the Office of the President. These changes put GIDD in a stronger position as it was given its own vote in the national budget and a better position from which to influence policy. Development theory has also changed from a focus on needs to support for rights. Basic rights are those rights which flow from people's basic needs such as water, food and housing. This is in recognition of the fact that WID interventions which focused on meeting the practical needs of women have not been successful. This is because they did not challenge fundamentally the structures that come in the way of women's participation in society on an equal basis with men.

Some benefits from focusing on gender in development

Impact of focusing on gender and development to community

1. Positive changes in gender relations and more respectful social attitudes towards women
2. More decision-making and political participation by women in the community
3. Women's increased knowledge of their legal rights
4. Greater likelihood that girls would stay in school
5. Reduced violence against women
6. Improved communication and mutual support between men and women on family planning, HIV and other sexually transmitted infections
7. Increased knowledge by men of women's health care issues